This particular royal correspondent had always made me ill. She'd always, always got stuff wrong. But this felt more than wrong.

I read the story in disbelief. Meg didn't. She still wasn't reading anything. She heard about it, however, since it was the only thing being discussed in Britain for the next twenty-four hours, and as long as I live I'll never forget the tone of her voice as she looked me in the eye and said:

Haz, I made her cry? I made HER cry?

57.

WE ARRANGED A SECOND summit with Willy and Kate.

This time on our turf.

December 10, 2018. Early evening.

We all gathered in our little front annex, and this time there was no small talk: Kate got things rolling straightaway by acknowledging that these stories in the papers about Meg making her cry were totally false. *I know, Meghan, that I was the one who made you cry.*

I sighed. Excellent start, I thought.

Meg appreciated the apology, but wanted to know why the papers had said this, and what was being done to correct them? In other words: *Why isn't your office standing up for me? Why haven't they phoned this execrable woman who wrote this story, and demanded a retraction?*

Kate, flustered, didn't answer, and Willy chimed in with some very supportive-sounding evasions, but I already knew the truth. No one at the Palace could phone the correspondent, because that would invite the inevitable retort: Well, if the story's wrong, what's the real story? What *did* happen between the two duchesses? And that door must never be opened, because it would embarrass the future queen.

The monarchy, always, at all costs, had to be protected.

We shifted from what to do about the story to where it came from. Who could've planted such a thing? Who could've leaked it to the press in the first place? Who?